

“The **relation of master and slave** ... is the **best that can exist** between the ... races.”

ROBERT E. LEE, MAY 1, 1865

Adviser and general

Despite these setbacks, Lee secured the enduring respect of Confederate president Jefferson Davis, who retained him as his personal military adviser. Using his engineering background, Lee set Confederate troops to digging extensive earthworks for the defense of Richmond. But by spring 1862, he had decided that the Confederates' only hope of success against a materially superior enemy lay in taking the offensive. Given command of the Army of Northern Virginia after the wounding of Joseph Johnston, Lee attacked the inert General George McClellan in the swift campaign known as the Seven Days Battles. Lee was still an inexperienced field commander, but he succeeded in driving the Union forces away from Richmond. After this triumph, his reputation was largely unassailable and he was able to pursue his own aggressive strategy.

Victories and fatal mistakes

Lee repeatedly took risks and, supported by his most gifted subordinate, Stonewall Jackson, his bold maneuvers secured outstanding offensive victories at Second Bull Run and Chancellorsville. Yet he came close to disaster through dividing his forces in the ill-judged invasion of Maryland in September 1862. Lee's decision not to retreat into Virginia but to stand and fight with a weary, outnumbered army at Antietam was a gamble, and would have been an opportunity for an opponent less cautious than McClellan. Antietam showed Lee's skill and resolution in a defensive battle and, with the success that followed at Fredericksburg, bolstered his belief in pursuing an offensive-